

CO1 - ASSESSMENT TOOL - 3

Course Code : ITA1407

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Course Name : Ethical Hacking

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Ethical Analysis of Reusing "Anonymized" Penetration Test Data:

A Cybersecurity firm offers clients a discount if they allow their anonymized penetration test data to be reused in public cases studied or training materials. Although this benefits both the firm and features learners, it raises important ethical concerns regarding "consent, anonymization and confidentiality".

1. Consent:

* Clients should provide "informed and voluntary consent" before their data is reused.

* The agreement must clearly explain:

- * What data will be shared.

- * How it will be anonymized.

- * Where it will be used.

* They should also have option to withdraw.

* Clients should not feel pressured into agreeing just because of the discount.

2. Anonymization :

- * Simply removing the company name may not be enough.
- * Sensitive details such as IP addresses, domain names, employee names, network diagrams, software version, and unique system configuration should also be removed or modified.
- * The firm has an ethical responsibility to ensure the anonymization process is thorough and effective.

3. Confidentiality :

- * Penetrating testing often reveals confidential information about an organisation's security weakness.
- * Even after anonymization, the firm must protect client data from unauthorized access or misuse.
- * Employees handling the data should follow strict confidentiality agreements.

4. Benefits of the Business Model :

- * Helps educate cyber security professionals using real-world examples.
- * Improves training quality and awareness of common security issues.
- * Clients receive a financial benefit through discounted services.

5. Ethical Risks:

- * Clients may agree mainly because of the discount rather than genuine willingness.
- * Incomplete anonymization may reveal the client's identity.
- * Public disclosure of security issues, even anonymously, may damage client trust if the organisation is recognized.
- * Misuse or accidental leakage of confidential information could result in legal and reputational consequences.

Conclusion:

This business model can be ethical only if the firm obtains "clear informed consent", applies "strong anonymization techniques" and maintains "strict confidentiality". Protecting client privacy and security must always take priority over business or educational benefits. Following ethical guidelines and legal requirements help build trust between the firm and its clients.